

The Number Everyone Quotes

San Miguel County says we need 1,114 homes. Only 182 of them are for people who already live here.

By Morgan Smith · Livable Telluride

If you have been to a housing meeting in the last year, you have heard the number. San Miguel County needs 1,114 homes. It turns up in staff reports, in grant applications, in newspaper stories, and in just about every argument for building something.

I went looking for where it came from.

The number comes from the County's 2025 Housing Needs Assessment, and I want to be fair to that document before I say anything else about it. Studies like this are genuinely hard. The consultants were asked to estimate something nobody can directly count, using whatever data a small rural county happens to have, which is not much. They did the job they were hired to do, and the report is more careful than the way people use it.

The trouble is that the number does not mean what most people think it means. Once you see what is inside it, a lot of the housing conversation here starts to look different.

What is actually inside the number

Of those 1,114 homes, about 182 are for households who already live in San Miguel County. People who are here now, working here now, and living somewhere that does not really work.

The other 932 are something else. Some are homes for people who commute in from down valley and might move here if there were anywhere to move to. Some are for jobs that are open today and cannot be filled. And a large share are for jobs that **do not exist yet**, at businesses that have not opened, based on a projection of how much our economy is expected to grow.

That is not an accusation. It is a description. But it means that when somebody says the county needs 1,114 homes, the honest translation is closer to this: the county

needs about 182 homes for the people who live here, and another 932 if we want the economy to keep growing at the rate somebody projected.

Those are two very different sentences. Only one of them ever gets said out loud.

How much weight can one number hold?

Here is what gives me pause, and none of it requires being a statistician.

It leans on a small, voluntary survey. The rent figures behind the study come from a regional survey that about 340 renters filled out. That is not nothing, but it is a small group for an entire county, and more importantly nobody was randomly chosen. People volunteered. In a housing survey, the people most likely to sit down and answer questions about housing are the people having housing problems. That does not make their answers wrong. It does mean the results probably lean toward more need rather than less, and there is no way to measure by how much.

There is nothing to check it against. None of our three governments keeps regular records of how many restricted apartments sit empty, how long the waiting lists actually are, or how many people apply for each opening. I looked for those records. They do not exist. So there is no way to hold the study up next to what is really happening inside the buildings and see whether the two agree.

The records we do have disagree with each other. In February, one count showed 41 empty units out of 212. Two months later another showed 49 empty out of 201. Both cannot be right, and the totals do not even match each other. Elsewhere, one Shandoka building is listed at 29 apartments in one adopted Town document and 12 in another. If we cannot agree on how many apartments we already own, it is fair to ask how much confidence to put in a projection of how many we will need in ten years.

Nobody asked the question that matters most. A need number with no price attached to it cannot tell you what to build. Our own community answered that question twice in the same year, and gave two completely opposite answers. When affordable homes went up for sale, six qualified households applied for every single one available. When new apartments came on the market at higher rents, barely more than one household applied per apartment, and five of them were still sitting empty

in December. Demand here is not one number. It changes enormously depending on what you charge, and a study that produces a single figure cannot capture that.

So I counted something myself

Since nobody around here keeps track of any of this, I decided to count something that has been sitting in plain sight the whole time. Every week the Telluride Times prints a help wanted section. I went through seventeen straight weeks of them, from the beginning of April through the first week of August, and wrote down every single job.

There were 172 of them. About half printed an actual wage, and most of those land somewhere between \$45,000 and \$65,000 a year. That is close to what the federal payroll figures say people here earn, which is reassuring in the sense that two completely different sources agree with each other, and discouraging in the sense that neither one comes anywhere near what it costs to live here.

But the thing that stopped me was smaller and stranger than that. **Seventeen of those advertisements offered housing as part of the job.** Not a signing bonus or a ski pass, but a place to live.

And the number kept growing as the season went on. In April, roughly one advertisement in eleven mentioned housing. By the middle of July it was two in every seven. Employers here have started competing on housing the way they used to compete on wages, and they are paying for the advertisement that says so. One of them is San Miguel County itself, which mentioned housing in its posting for a Planning Director.

Here is why that matters for the number everyone quotes. **Every one of those 172 jobs already exists.** Somebody is already doing that work, or nobody is and a business is short-handed because of it. These are not jobs from a projection or a growth model. They are jobs on a page, printed on a Thursday, in a paper you can pick up at the market.

The people who would fill them are the 182, not the 932.

Two different problems wearing the same name

Picture two people.

The first is a line cook who has worked at the same restaurant for six years and sleeps on a friend's couch. Or a teacher sharing an apartment with a roommate she did not choose. Or the plow driver who leaves Montrose at half past four in the morning. These people already work here. They are already part of this community in every way except one. Housing them does not add a single person to this valley. It moves people who are already here into somewhere they can actually live.

The second is a job that does not exist yet, at a business that has not opened, eventually filled by somebody who does not live here now. Building housing for that person is a decision to grow. That is a perfectly legitimate thing for a community to choose, and plenty of places choose it deliberately and are glad they did.

But these are not the same decision. They do not cost the same. They do not put the same pressure on the sewer plant, the highway, or the schools. And they do not end in the same place.

Right now we make both decisions using one number, which means we mostly make the second decision without ever noticing we made it.

Why this matters more than it sounds

Here is the part that took me a while to see clearly.

Housing built for growth does not simply use up capacity. It creates more of the very thing it was supposed to fix. Every new hotel, restaurant, and shop needs workers. Those workers need housing. Housing those workers creates demand for more services, which needs more workers, who need more housing. The number never shrinks, because the number is chasing itself.

Housing built for people who already live here does not behave that way. The job already exists. The worker already buys groceries here and pays for a haircut here. Nothing new gets added except somebody finally getting a decent place to sleep.

That is the difference between a housing program that can be finished and one that cannot. And it is the reason I think the first question we ask about any housing

proposal should not be how many units it has. It should be which of those two problems it is trying to solve.

What comes next

This is the first of several pieces I am working on. Over the coming weeks I want to walk through what our housing actually costs to build, why some of it fills instantly while other buildings sit empty, what our sewer plant has to do with all of it, and what the cheapest ways to house a working person actually are. Some of what I found surprised me, and a fair amount of it is encouraging.

For now, the next time you hear the number, it is worth asking a simple follow-up question. How many of those homes are for the people who are already here?

The answer is 182.

Livable Telluride is an independent community organization. Every figure here comes from public records, and the full analysis with sources is at livabletelluride.org. If you think I have something wrong, tell me and I will publish the correction.